

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Hard

Question

Nigerian author Buchi Emecheta’s celebrated literary oeuvre includes *The Joys of Motherhood*, a novel about the changing roles of women in 1950s _____ a television play about the private struggles of a newlywed couple in Nigeria; and *Head Above Water*, her autobiography.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Lagos, *A Kind of Marriage*,
- B. Lagos; *A Kind of Marriage*,
- C. Lagos, *A Kind of Marriage*:
- D. Lagos; *A Kind of Marriage*

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series (a series including internal punctuation). In this choice, the semicolon after “Lagos” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“*The Joys*...Lagos”) and the second item (“*A Kind*...Nigeria”) in the series. Further, the comma after “*Marriage*” correctly separates the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it.

Choice A is incorrect because the comma after “Lagos” doesn’t match the semicolon used later in the series to separate the second item (“*A Kind*...Nigeria”) from the third item (“and...autobiography”). Choice C is incorrect because the comma after “Lagos” doesn’t match the semicolon used later in the series to separate the second item (“*A Kind*...Nigeria”) from the third item (“and...autobiography”). Additionally, a colon can’t be used in this way to separate the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it.